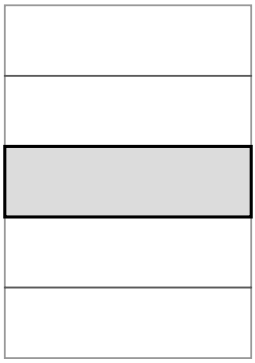
The Mom Test Conversational Protocol

We believe that [target customer segment] experiences severe operational inefficiency when [executing specific task]. We will verify this by conducting 12 conversational interviews focusing exclusively on past actions, and consider it validated if at least 8 of 12 respondents independently describe a dedicated, imperfect workaround they used within the last 14 days without prompting.



SCHEMATIC

Moderate confidence: rung 3 of 5

I01

The Mom Test Conversational Protocol

METHOD

Time: 5–7 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: Moderate (Qualitative behavioral)

PLAN

Preparation Write five prompts about past events; strip every reference to a solution, a business or a hypothetical.
Execution Run 30-minute interviews anchored in the last time they did the task, what it cost, and what they tried first.
Data collection Transcribe verbatim; label each line historical behaviour, speculation or feeling, and drop speculation.

FALSE POSITIVE

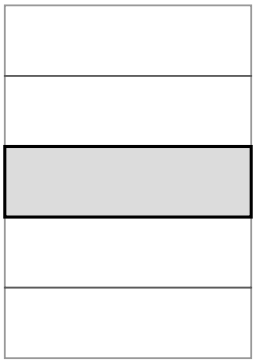
Courtesy Bias

Show your concept and interviewees politely affirm it to avoid friction, manufacturing validation.

Source: Rob Fitzpatrick (2013). *The Mom Test.* Robfitz.

Blank Customer Problem Discovery Interview

We believe that [industry persona] suffers from [critical operational bottleneck]. We will verify this by executing 15 structured problem interviews across 3 distinct sub-verticals, and consider it validated if ≥ 70% of interviewees rank this problem as one of their top two operational challenges for the current fiscal quarter.



SCHEMATIC

Moderate confidence: rung 3 of 5

I02

Blank Customer Problem Discovery Interview

METHOD

Time: 7–10 days · Cost: $0–$100 · Confidence: Moderate

PLAN

Preparation Define the ideal customer profile from firmographic traits; frame outreach as research, not a sales pitch.
Execution Ask for the quarter's top three operational priorities and see whether the problem surfaces unprompted.
Data collection Score urgency one to five from documented budget, executive visibility and active software evaluations.

FALSE POSITIVE

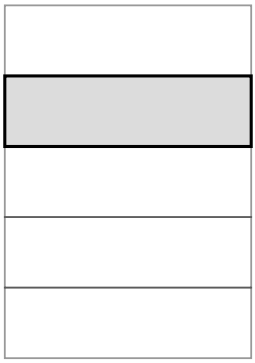
Polite Problem Inflation

Interviewees lament minor inconveniences they have no budget or mandate to resolve.

The source names no originator.

Jobs-to-Be-Done (JTBD) Switch and Forces Interview

We believe that [persona] switches away from [incumbent solution] primarily due to [catalyzing push/pull force]. We will verify this by interviewing 10 individuals who transitioned between solutions within the last 90 days, and consider it validated if ≥ 60% point to the exact same triggering event and emotional crisis point.



SCHEMATIC

Moderate-High confidence: rung 4 of 5

I03

Jobs-to-Be-Done (JTBD) Switch and Forces Interview

METHOD

Time: 7–14 days · Cost: $0–$250 · Confidence: Moderate-High

PLAN

Preparation Recruit ten people who switched in the last 90 days and build the four-force inquiry matrix.
Execution Walk the arc - first thought, active looking, deciding, consuming - and ask what nearly stopped the purchase.
Data collection Map the active forces on a matrix, keeping push mechanisms apart from feature wishlists.

FALSE POSITIVE

Post-Hoc Rationalization

Buyers build coherent narratives for decisions that were emotional, impulsive or organisational.

Source: Clayton M. Christensen, Taddy Hall, Karen Dillon & David S. Duncan (2016). *Competing Against Luck: The Story of Innovation and Customer Choice.* HarperBusiness.

Ethnographic Contextual Inquiry (Shadowing)

We believe that [operators] face unrecorded cognitive overload while [operating system X]. We will verify this by observing 6 operators in their natural workplace for 4 hours each, and consider it validated if we record ≥ 5 unprompted compensatory mechanisms (e.g., sticky notes, personal spreadsheets, ad-hoc scripts) per operator per shift.



SCHEMATIC

High confidence: rung 5 of 5

I04

Ethnographic Contextual Inquiry (Shadowing)

METHOD

Time: 10–14 days · Cost: $0–$500 · Confidence: High (Direct observation)

PLAN

Preparation Clear confidentiality and access; build a ledger for micro-interruptions, non-verbal cues and app switches.
Execution Observe silently through a shift; interrupt only on a deviation and ask what motivated that step.
Data collection Compile a minute-by-minute trace of application switches, error recovery, movement and distraction.

FALSE POSITIVE

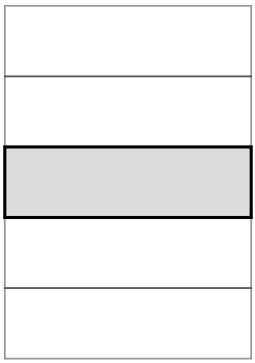
Hawthorne Effect

Observed operators tidy their workarounds and follow formal protocol because someone is watching.

Source: Hugh Beyer & Karen Holtzblatt (1998). *Contextual Design: Defining Customer-Centered Systems.* Morgan Kaufmann.

Value Proposition Canvas Customer Profiling

We believe that [customer segment] considers [pain point Y] significantly more critical than [pain point Z]. We will verify this by conducting 10 canvas alignment exercises, and consider it validated if ≥ 75% of participants independently cluster their top 3 jobs and pains into identical operational nodes.



SCHEMATIC

Moderate confidence: rung 3 of 5

I05

Value Proposition Canvas Customer Profiling

METHOD

Time: 3–5 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: Moderate

PLAN

Preparation Lay out an empty customer profile of jobs, pains and gains on a board that participants can move. **Execution** Run an unmoderated card sort into functional, social and emotional categories, then rank pains and gains. **Data collection** Record where items cluster and correlate the rankings across participants.

FALSE POSITIVE

Aspirational Self-Deception

People elevate noble social and emotional jobs above the mundane functional tasks that decide the purchase.

Source: Alexander Osterwalder, Yves Pigneur, Gregory Bernarda & Alan Smith (2014). *Value Proposition Design: How to Create Products and Services Customers Want.* John Wiley & Sons.

Customer Churn and Exit Interview Mining

We believe that customers abandon [incumbent solution category] because of [deficiency X]. We will verify this by auditing 20 canceled customer accounts or exit interviews, and consider it validated if ≥ 50% identify [deficiency X] as their primary non-negotiable exit driver rather than pricing or budget constraints.



SCHEMATIC

High confidence: rung 5 of 5

I06

Customer Churn and Exit Interview Mining

METHOD

Time: 7–12 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: High (Post-behavioral)

PLAN

Preparation Pull accounts cancelled in the last 30 to 60 days; frame the call as a process post-mortem, not a win-back.
Execution Ask when value stopped, what workaround they built before leaving, and what replaced the product.
Data collection Code each exit into price, product defect, reorganisation or loss of internal champion.

FALSE POSITIVE

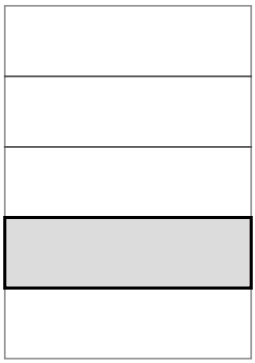
Scapegoat Rationalization

Churned clients blame price or a peripheral bug rather than admit the organisation could not adopt it.

The source names no originator.

Public Community and Social Sentiment Mining

We believe that users of [incumbent software] are actively seeking alternatives due to [specific systemic flaw]. We will verify this by analyzing 300 unresolved negative comments and support threads across industry forums, and consider it validated if ≥ 25% of organic complaint threads focus specifically on [flaw].



SCHEMATIC

Low-Moderate confidence: rung 2 of 5

I07

Public Community and Social Sentiment Mining

METHOD

Time: 3–5 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: Low-Moderate

PLAN

Preparation Map the practitioner communities: specialist forums, issue trackers, subreddits and professional groups.
Execution Search with diagnostic boolean strings - how do I fix, alternative to, terrible UX, workaround.
Data collection Group complaints into themes, reported losses and the operational driver under each.

FALSE POSITIVE

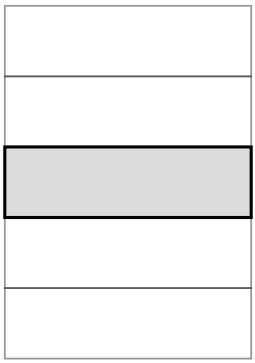
Selection Bias of Vocal Minorities

Public threads amplify edge-case power users whose needs diverge from the mainstream market.

The source names no originator.

Customer Advisory Board Problem Council

We believe that [industry vertical] executives consider [nascent regulatory or operational challenge] a board-level risk. We will verify this by hosting a 6-executive roundtable, and consider it validated if ≥ 4 members confirm they have formally committed budget to mitigate the issue in the current fiscal year.



SCHEMATIC

Moderate confidence: rung 3 of 5

I08

Customer Advisory Board Problem Council

METHOD

Time: 14–21 days · Cost: $500–$$$ · Confidence: Moderate

PLAN

Preparation Recruit six non-competing executives and frame the session as an off-the-record working council.
Execution Under the Chatham House Rule, have each name their single greatest vulnerability, with no product pitch.
Data collection Record how peers validate each other, which budget lines are disclosed, and which problems recur.

FALSE POSITIVE

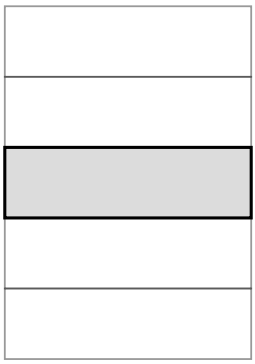
Executive Echo Chamber

Executives echo industry buzzwords to look forward-thinking before peers, regardless of budget.

The source names no originator.

Search Intent and Semantic Volume Reconnaissance

We believe that consumers are actively searching for ways to solve [problem X]. We will verify this by analyzing search engine queries across targeted keyword groups, and consider it validated if high-intent terms show ≥ 2,500 monthly organic queries with a year-over-year growth rate of ≥ 20%.



SCHEMATIC

Moderate confidence: rung 3 of 5

I09

Search Intent and Semantic Volume Reconnaissance

METHOD

Time: 2–4 days · Cost: $0–$150 · Confidence: Moderate (Intent-based)

PLAN

Preparation Compile seed variants of high-intent syntax: how to automate X, X alternative, X compliance template.
Execution Query volume databases for regional density, historical trend, cost per click and competitor saturation.
Data collection Split queries into informational, navigational, commercial and transactional, then total commercial volume.

FALSE POSITIVE

Informational Intent Conflation

High informational volume can mean curiosity or free-guide seekers, not buyers with commercial intent.

The source names no originator.

Critical Incident Technique (CIT) Audit

We believe that [event X] triggers operational failure in [workflow Y]. We will verify this by collecting 15 detailed critical incident reports from practitioners, and consider it validated if ≥ 80% report that the incident caused acute workflow delays, compliance exposure, or direct financial loss.



SCHEMATIC

High confidence: rung 5 of 5

I10

Critical Incident Technique (CIT) Audit

METHOD

Time: 5–8 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: High (Incident-focused)

PLAN

Preparation Set explicit inclusion criteria for a critical incident: downtime, SLA breach or emergency briefing.
Execution Ask practitioners to recount the most recent failure, the conditions before it, and what failed in response.
Data collection Build a chronological event map per incident: root trigger, compounding effects, downstream cost.

FALSE POSITIVE

Salience and Availability Bias

Vivid crises are remembered clearly and mistaken for routine, recurring market needs.

Source: John C. Flanagan (1954). *The Critical Incident Technique.* Psychological Bulletin.

Desirability, Feasibility, and Viability (DFV) Mapping

We believe that our cross-functional team holds strategic alignment on our core business vulnerabilities. We will verify this by mapping all operational assumptions across a 2 × 2 matrix (Impact vs. Evidence), and consider it validated if participants achieve ≥ 90% consensus on the top 5 assumptions categorized in the High Impact / Low Evidence quadrant.



SCHEMATIC

Low confidence: rung 1 of 5

I11

Desirability, Feasibility, and Viability (DFV) Mapping

METHOD

Time: 1–2 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: Low (Conceptual alignment)

PLAN

Preparation Assemble product, engineering, design and commercial leads with desirability, feasibility, viability cards.
Execution Have each write their explicit premises, then place every assumption on a shared impact-by-evidence grid.
Data collection Cluster overlapping cards into themes and isolate high-impact, low-evidence as the experiment backlog.

FALSE POSITIVE

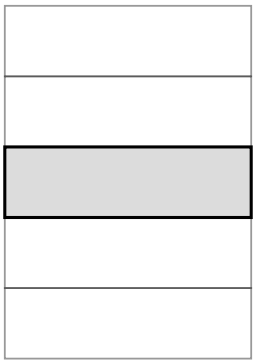
HiPPO Distortion

Senior executives drag risky assumptions into the known quadrant on personal conviction.

The source names no originator.

Riskiest Assumption Test (RAT) Decomposition

We believe that [Assumption A] represents the single existential bottleneck for the business model. We will verify this by decomposing the business concept into causal dependency trees, and consider it validated if breaking this single assumption mathematically invalidates all downstream unit economics.



SCHEMATIC

Moderate confidence: rung 3 of 5

I12

Riskiest Assumption Test (RAT) Decomposition

METHOD

Time: 2–3 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: Moderate

PLAN

Preparation Take the top-ranked assumption from the DFV matrix and break it into discrete component premises.
Execution Build a causal tree of what must be true and trace back to the premise whose failure collapses it.
Data collection Write the test specification for that root: thresholds, time boundaries and required evidence weight.

FALSE POSITIVE

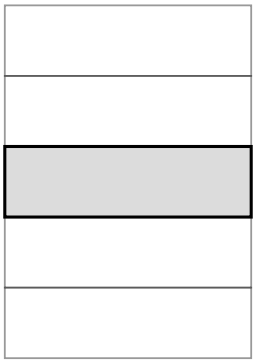
Premature Optimization of Secondary Assumptions

Teams test easy details - interface polish, onboarding copy - while skipping the existential risk.

The source names no originator.

Problem-Solution Fit Scorecarding

We believe our proposed solution addresses the primary pain points discovered in Phase 1. We will verify this by scoring our feature set against validated customer problems using a blind scoring rubric, and consider it validated if ≥ 80% of features map directly to high-severity problems, with all secondary unmapped features eliminated.



SCHEMATIC

Moderate confidence: rung 3 of 5

I13

Problem-Solution Fit Scorecarding

METHOD

Time: 3–5 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: Moderate

PLAN

Preparation List validated customer problems on the vertical axis and proposed feature specifications across the top.
Execution For each intersection ask whether the feature relieves that problem, and justify it with phase-one data.
Data collection Compute the coverage ratio; drop features that solve unvalidated problems or miss the core bottleneck.

FALSE POSITIVE

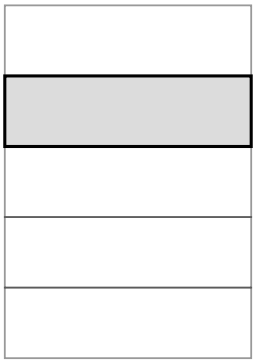
Sunk Cost Feature Attachment

Teams write elaborate post-hoc justifications for favourite features with no link to validated problems.

The source names no originator.

Stakeholder and Buying Center Influence Mapping (B2B)

We believe that [Role A] controls purchase authority, while [Role B] serves as an internal champion. We will verify this by mapping the buying center dynamics across 8 enterprise target accounts, and consider it validated if the operational economic buyer matches our target persona in ≥ 75% of evaluated org charts.



SCHEMATIC

Moderate-High confidence: rung 4 of 5

I14

Stakeholder and Buying Center Influence Mapping (B2B)

METHOD

Time: 5–7 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: Moderate-High

PLAN

Preparation Define the six buying roles: economic buyer, champion, end user, technical gatekeeper, procurement, blocker.
Execution Call across departments in each account and ask whose budget pays and who holds the veto in review.
Data collection Chart the decision, veto and capital-authorisation path for each of the eight accounts.

FALSE POSITIVE

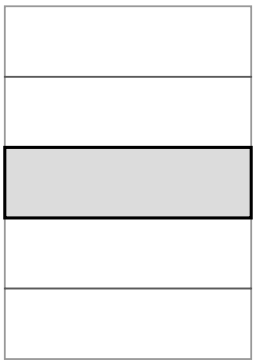
Champion Conflation

An enthusiastic end user is mistaken for the economic buyer, and the deal stalls at procurement.

The source names no originator.

Value Proposition Fit Matrix (Relievers vs. Pains)

We believe that our core value proposition outranks existing market alternatives on speed and clarity. We will verify this by presenting a relative comparison matrix to 12 prospective users, and consider it validated if ≥ 70% prioritize our specific pain relievers over incumbent alternatives.



SCHEMATIC

Moderate confidence: rung 3 of 5

I15

Value Proposition Fit Matrix (Relievers vs. Pains)

METHOD

Time: 2–4 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: Moderate

PLAN

Preparation Build a two-sided canvas that maps pain relievers to customer pains and gain creators to gains. **Execution** Have target users rate each element's clarity, relevance and difference against their current alternative. **Data collection** Score fit with a weighted model calibrated to the pains users ranked highest.

FALSE POSITIVE

Theoretical Value Congruence

A proposition can read as cohesive and compelling on paper and still not move anyone off the incumbent.

Source: Alexander Osterwalder, Yves Pigneur, Gregory Bernarda & Alan Smith (2014). *Value Proposition Design: How to Create Products and Services Customers Want.* John Wiley & Sons.

Reverse-Income Economic Viability Model

We believe this business model can achieve sustainable profitability at target scale. We will verify this by building a reverse unit-economics model, and consider it validated if the required conversion rates and average revenue per user (ARPU) remain within historical benchmark ranges for this industry vertical.



SCHEMATIC

High confidence: rung 5 of 5

I16

Reverse-Income Economic Viability Model

METHOD

Time: 1–2 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: High (Mathematical proof)

PLAN

Preparation Fix an ambitious revenue milestone, such as ten million in annual recurring revenue.
Execution Work backward from revenue: required customers = ARR / ARPU, then conversion and acquisition cost.
Data collection Check the required metrics against benchmarks: Required Leads = Target ARR / (ARPU × Funnel Conversion Rate).

FALSE POSITIVE

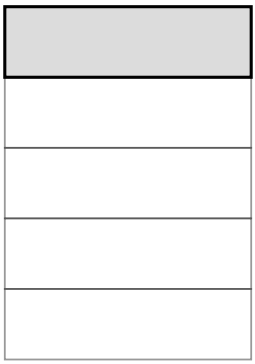
Spreadsheet Viability Syndrome

A model balances by inserting aggressive growth or fantasy acquisition costs, hiding an unviable business.

The source names no originator.

Technical Feasibility Spike and Architecture Proof

We believe that [external API / architecture] can process [X volume] within [Y latency]. We will verify this by deploying an isolated technical spike in a staging environment, and consider it validated if latency remains below 250ms at 1,500 concurrent requests without data loss.



SCHEMATIC

High confidence: rung 5 of 5

I17

Technical Feasibility Spike and Architecture Proof

METHOD

Time: 3–7 days · Cost: $0–$$$ · Confidence: High (Empirical technical)

PLAN

Preparation Strip the front end and every non-essential dependency; isolate the one algorithmic or throughput unknown.
Execution Build the smallest codebase that can stress the integration, algorithm or pipeline at the target load.
Data collection Run automated load scripts and log latency distribution, memory, error codes and compute cost.

FALSE POSITIVE

Sandbox Isolation Bias

A clean staging spike degrades on real edge cases, dirty legacy data and unoptimised production dependencies.

The source names no originator.

Regulatory and Compliance Gate Audit

We believe our proposed data architecture complies fully with relevant regulatory standards (e.g., GDPR, HIPAA, SOC2). We will verify this by completing a formal compliance audit with an external specialist, and consider it validated if the audit reveals zero critical regulatory blockers that would require fundamentally altering the product model.



SCHEMATIC

High confidence: rung 5 of 5

I18

Regulatory and Compliance Gate Audit

METHOD

Time: 5–10 days · Cost: $0–$$$$ · Confidence: High

PLAN

Preparation Document data lifecycles, consent mechanisms, storage tiers and cross-border transfer paths.
Execution Walk legal and compliance specialists through the end-to-end data flow to find every regulatory touchpoint.
Data collection Log legal hurdles, certification costs and implementation timelines against the product model.

FALSE POSITIVE

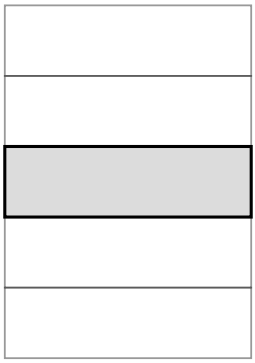
Informal Legal Assurances

Casual early guidance from corporate counsel is mistaken for formal, binding regulatory clearance.

The source names no originator.

Acquisition Channel Scalability Matrix

We believe that [Channel X] can sustainably deliver customer acquisition at targeted unit costs. We will verify this by cross-referencing industry channel benchmarks against product characteristics, and consider it validated if the channel delivers an estimated CAC:LTV ratio of ≥ 1:3 at target market scale.



SCHEMATIC

Moderate confidence: rung 3 of 5

I19

Acquisition Channel Scalability Matrix

METHOD

Time: 3–5 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: Moderate

PLAN

Preparation Map candidate acquisition channels against ARPU tiers and the way the target users actually buy.
Execution Drop channels that cannot carry the price point - enterprise direct sales rarely pays below $1,000 ARPU.
Data collection Build a projection matrix of saturation, cost-per-click trend and conversion assumptions per channel.

FALSE POSITIVE

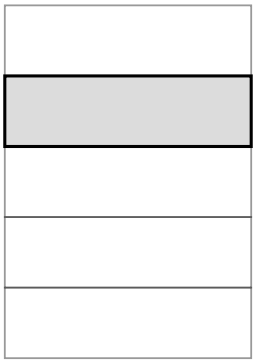
Channel Mirage Effect

Traction in niche or closed communities rarely scales when broad advertising is switched on.

The source names no originator.

Van Westendorp Price Sensitivity Meter

We believe that the acceptable price band for our offering falls between [Price A] and [Price B]. We will verify this by surveying 50 qualified target customers using the four standard Van Westendorp questions, and consider it validated if the Indifference Price Point aligns with our planned market pricing within a ±10% margin.



SCHEMATIC

Moderate-High confidence: rung 4 of 5

I20

Van Westendorp Price Sensitivity Meter

METHOD

Time: 5–7 days · Cost: $50–$300 · Confidence: Moderate-High

PLAN

Preparation Build the survey around the four price questions: too cheap, a bargain, getting expensive, too expensive.
Execution Send the instrument only to qualified buyers who match the defined ideal customer profile.
Data collection Plot the cumulative curves; read the indifference and optimal price points and compare with the plan price.

FALSE POSITIVE

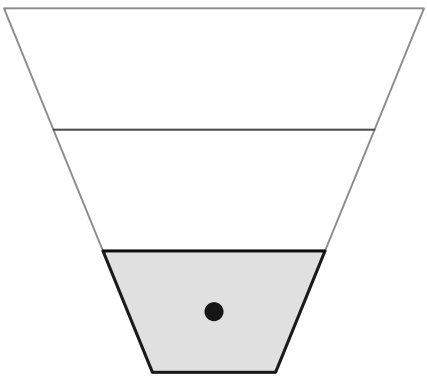
Stated Willingness Bias

Stated-price surveys overestimate what people pay when asked to enter real payment details.

Source: Peter H. Van Westendorp (1976). *NSS-Price Sensitivity Meter (PSM): A New Approach to Study Consumer Perception of Price.* Proceedings of the 29th ESOMAR Congress.

Fake Door / Ghost Feature Test

We believe that existing active users need [Feature X]. We will verify this by adding an entry point for the unbuilt feature within our live interface, and consider it validated if ≥ 12% of active users click the link within 7 days, with ≥ 50% opting into an early access notification list.



SCHEMATIC

Read at stage 3 of the 3-stage funnel

I21

Fake Door / Ghost Feature Test

METHOD

Time: 3–5 days · Cost: $0–$50 · Confidence: High (Behavioral commitment)

PLAN

Preparation Design a native entry point for the unbuilt feature with a modal offering an early-access waitlist.
Execution Ship it to a randomised slice of active users behind an open-source feature flag.
Data collection Track exposures, click-through and opt-in conversions on the modal.

FALSE POSITIVE

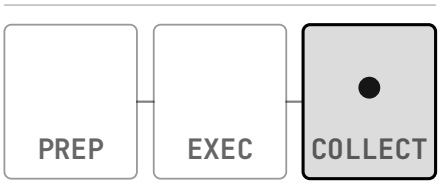
Curio-Clicking

Users click novel buttons out of curiosity, not because they want the feature.

The source names no originator.

Landing Page Smoke Test

We believe cold traffic from [Channel A] will convert on [Core Value Proposition]. We will verify this by driving 1,000 qualified visitors to a standalone landing page, and consider it validated if the conversion rate (email capture or pricing tier selection) meets or exceeds 5.0% with a target Cost Per Acquisition (CPA) below $15.00.



SCHEMATIC

Read at step 3 of the 3-step strip

I22

Landing Page Smoke Test

METHOD

Time: 7–14 days · Cost: $100–$500 · Confidence: High

PLAN

Preparation Build one page with headline, value pillars, proof and a single call to action; instrument every button.
Execution Buy targeted search or social traffic from the ideal customer profile and send it to the page.
Data collection Track unique visitors, bounce, dwell time and conversion on the primary call to action.

FALSE POSITIVE

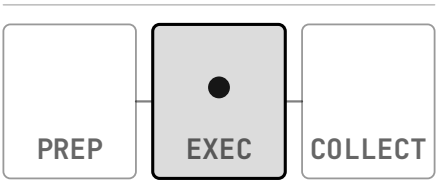
Vanity Email Opt-Ins

Visitors hand over burner emails for a free download with no intention of paying.

The source names no originator.

Concierge Minimum Viable Product

We believe that [client segment] will pay for [automated service outcome]. We will verify this by manually delivering the service end-to-end for 5 businesses for three consecutive weeks, and consider it validated if ≥ 4 clients complete the trial and agree to retain the service on a paid monthly basis.



SCHEMATIC

Delivery at step 2 of the 3-step strip

I23

Concierge Minimum Viable Product

METHOD

Time: 2–4 weeks · Cost: $0–$200 · Confidence: Very High (Operational truth)

PLAN

Preparation Define the manual workflow, tools and client channel, and say the onboarding is white-glove.
Execution Deliver every unit by hand and count the human hours each one costs.
Data collection Log satisfaction, hours per delivery, edge cases and retention.

FALSE POSITIVE

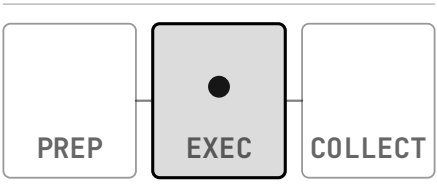
White-Glove Bias

Clients stay for the attentive human, then churn when the software replaces it.

The source names no originator.

Wizard of Oz Prototype

We believe customers will trust an automated interface to handle [complex task]. We will verify this by building a functioning frontend facade operated entirely by humans on the back end, and consider it validated if users process ≥ 50 transactions with an average Net Promoter Score (NPS) ≥ 50 and an error rate below 5%.



SCHEMATIC

Delivery at step 2 of the 3-step strip

I24

Wizard of Oz Prototype

METHOD

Time: 2–4 weeks · Cost: $100–$1,000 · Confidence: Very High

PLAN

Preparation Build a polished front end wired to internal dashboards or spreadsheets instead of an automated backend.
Execution Have people process each request in real time and answer through the interface.
Data collection Log turnaround time, interaction patterns, failures and completion.

FALSE POSITIVE

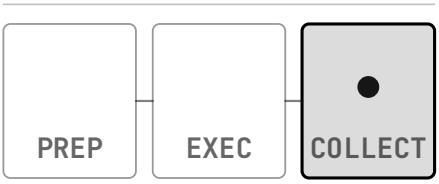
Unsustainable Fulfillment Expectations

Operators smooth over bad data, faking product-market fit that breaks under automation.

The source names no originator.

Explainer Video Smoke Test (The Dropbox Prototype)

We believe our proposed workflow interface is intuitive enough to drive mass consumer adoption. We will verify this by posting a 2-minute demonstration video showing simulated software interactions to target developer channels, and consider it validated if the waitlist grows by ≥ 10,000 qualified signups within 48 hours.



SCHEMATIC

Read at step 3 of the 3-step strip

I25

Explainer Video Smoke Test (The Dropbox Prototype)

METHOD

Time: 5–10 days · Cost: $50–$300 · Confidence: Moderate-High

PLAN

Preparation Cut a two-minute video of the core workflows, showing the frustration it removes.
Execution Seed it in niche developer communities and link to an early-access waitlist.
Data collection Track retention drop-off, views, landing conversion and the tone of discussion.

FALSE POSITIVE

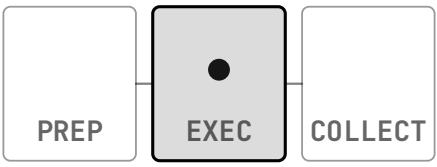
Entertainment and Novelty Virality

A clever video earns shares, not paying users, once the novelty wears off.

The source names no originator.

Interactive Paper Prototyping

We believe that users can navigate our core onboarding flow without training. We will verify this by running 8 paper-prototype usability sessions, and consider it validated if ≥ 7 participants complete the primary conversion path without asking the facilitator for assistance.



SCHEMATIC

Session at step 2 of the 3-step strip

I26

Interactive Paper Prototyping

METHOD

Time: 2–3 days · Cost: $10–$50 · Confidence: Moderate (Task ergonomics)

PLAN

Preparation Sketch screens, dropdowns and modals on index cards the facilitator can swap quickly.
Execution Give one task; as the user taps paper, the facilitator plays the computer and lays the next state.
Data collection Note hesitation, mis-taps, spoken confusion and time to finish.

FALSE POSITIVE

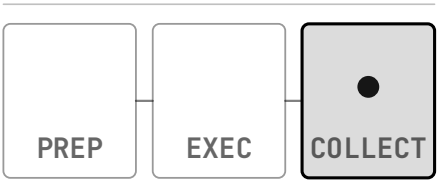
Facilitator Coaxing

Facilitators nod and coax through hesitations, hiding the flaw they were testing for.

The source names no originator.

Clickable Wireframe Click-Stream Prototype

We believe that users can configure their account settings in under 90 seconds. We will verify this by testing an interactive, clickable mock prototype with 15 unassisted target users, and consider it validated if the median Time-to-Complete is under 90 seconds with a task success rate ≥ 80%.



SCHEMATIC

Read at step 3 of the 3-step strip

I27

Clickable Wireframe Click-Stream Prototype

METHOD

Time: 4–7 days · Cost: $0–$100 · Confidence: Moderate-High

PLAN

Preparation Build a mid-fidelity clickable prototype with real click states and input fields; leave side branches dead.
Execution Send the link through an unmoderated tool and ask participants to think aloud at one goal.
Data collection Track success paths, misclick heat, task duration and where people drop.

FALSE POSITIVE

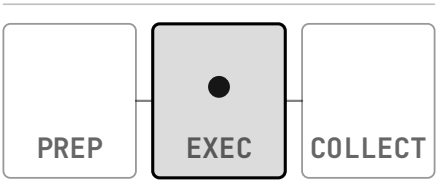
Missing Operational Context

A mockup in a test window has none of the interruptions, dirty data or friction of the real job.

The source names no originator.

Crowdfunding Pre-Sales Campaign

We believe there is sustained market demand for our hardware/software innovation. We will verify this by launching a 30-day public crowdfunding campaign, and consider it validated if the campaign hits its minimum funding goal of $100,000 from at least 500 individual backers.



SCHEMATIC

Pledge at step 2 of the 3-step strip

I28

Crowdfunding Pre-Sales Campaign

METHOD

Time: 30–60 days · Cost: unreadable in the source ($$–$$ * $$) · Confidence: Extreme (Irrevocable capital)

PLAN

Preparation Make the campaign video, fix production dates, cost the bill of materials and set the reward tiers.
Execution Launch publicly and run coordinated promotion through the target consumer and industry channels.
Data collection Track day-one funding velocity, page conversion, tier mix and average pledge.

FALSE POSITIVE

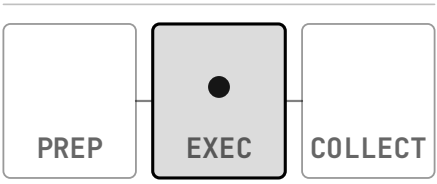
Early-Adopter Crowdfunding Bubble

Crowdfunding draws hobbyists who tolerate delay and bugs, not mainstream buyers.

The source names no originator.

B2B Letter of Intent (LOI) Protocol

We believe mid-market enterprises need our proposed integration. We will verify this by presenting a non-binding Letter of Intent (LOI) to 6 prospective enterprise accounts, and consider it validated if at least 2 authorized executives sign the document committing to a paid commercial pilot upon delivery of agreed functional specifications.



SCHEMATIC

Signature at step 2 of the 3-step strip

I29

B2B Letter of Intent (LOI) Protocol

METHOD

Time: 2–4 weeks · Cost: $0 · Confidence: Extreme (Enterprise legal intent)

PLAN

Preparation Draft a one-page non-binding letter: the problem, the deliverables, the go-live date and pilot pricing.
Execution Present it to the economic buyer once the requirements are defined in the sales conversation.
Data collection Note hesitation, legal and procurement redlines, and how many sign.

FALSE POSITIVE

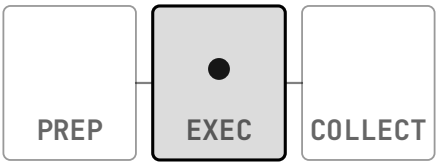
Non-Binding Courtesy Signatures

Sympathetic executives sign a non-binding letter to be kind, then vanish at procurement.

The source names no originator.

Refundable Deposit Pre-Order

We believe users will pay [Price Y] for our forthcoming product. We will verify this by running a pre-order campaign with a required, refundable $50 reservation deposit, and consider it validated if ≥ 3.0% of unique page visitors complete the checkout transaction.



SCHEMATIC

Payment at step 2 of the 3-step strip

I30

Refundable Deposit Pre-Order

METHOD

Time: 7–14 days · Cost: $100–$500 · Confidence: Extreme (Financial commitment)

PLAN

Preparation State the product is in development and offer priority queue placement for a refundable deposit.
Execution Drive qualified traffic to the reservation page and process real payments via a gateway.
Data collection Measure payment completion, refunds requested, and checkout questions.

FALSE POSITIVE

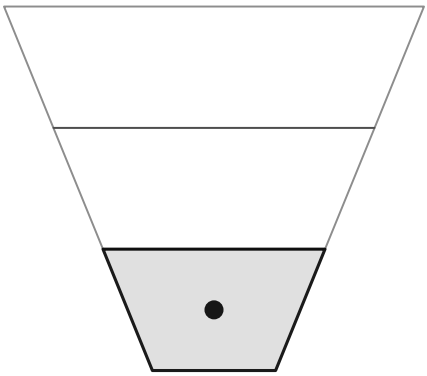
Frictionless Refund Psychology

When deposits are low and refundable, buyers treat checkout as a bookmark rather than a commitment.

The source names no originator.

Micro-Ad Engagement Funnel Siphon

We believe that [Value Proposition Messaging A] resonates more strongly with consumers than [Messaging B]. We will verify this by running split ad campaigns with equal budget allocations across both messages, and consider it validated if Variant A yields a ≥ 40% higher Click-Through Rate (CTR) and ≥ 25% lower Cost Per Click (CPC) at statistical significance ($p < 0.05$).



SCHEMATIC

Read at stage 3 of the 3-stage funnel

I31

Micro-Ad Engagement Funnel Siphon

METHOD

Time: 3–5 days · Cost: $150–$300 · Confidence: Moderate-High

PLAN

Preparation Make identical assets that differ only in the headline: cost savings against time savings.
Execution Run both ad sets at once on one platform, to one audience, with daily caps to avoid skew.
Data collection Track impressions, clicks, click-through and downstream page engagement per variant.

FALSE POSITIVE

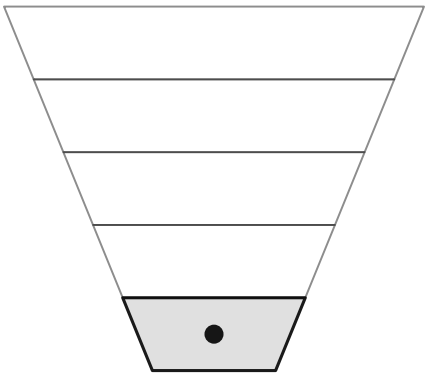
Clickbait Disconnection

Curiosity copy wins clicks and cheap traffic that bounces on the real product page.

The source names no originator.

Pirate Metrics (AARRR) Baseline Funnel Audit

We believe that our product funnel converts prospects efficiently from initial discovery through to paid renewal. We will verify this by instrumenting end-to-end event telemetry across all five funnel stages, and consider it validated if we achieve baseline conversions of ≥ 20% Acquisition-to-Activation and ≥ 5% Activation-to-Revenue.



SCHEMATIC

Read at stage 5 of the 5-stage funnel

I32

Pirate Metrics (AARRR) Baseline Funnel Audit

METHOD

Time: 14–30 days · Cost: $0–$100 · Confidence: High

PLAN

Preparation Define one metric per stage: landing visitor, value moment, 7-day return, payment executed, invite dispatched.
Execution Instrument an analytics event for each step on an open-source analytics or warehouse platform.
Data collection Build the funnel view and track conversion percentage and velocity between successive steps.

FALSE POSITIVE

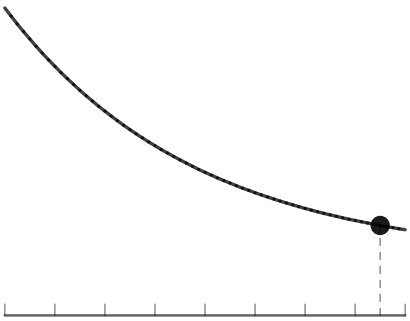
Blended Funnel Distortions

One blended average hides channel differences: weak paid traffic dilutes strong organic intent.

Source: Dave McClure (2007). *Startup Metrics for Pirates: AARRR!* Ignite Seattle.

Cohort Retention Decay Curve Analysis

We believe that our product delivers sustained, long-term utility to users. We will verify this by tracking weekly active usage across monthly cohorts, and consider it validated if the retention curve flattens into a stable horizontal asymptote at ≥ 20% weekly active retention by Week 8: lim R(t) as t ⟶ ∞ ≥ 0.20



SCHEMATIC

Week 8 retention on the decay curve

I33

Cohort Retention Decay Curve Analysis

METHOD

Time: 30–60 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: Extreme (Product-Market Fit ground truth)

PLAN

Preparation Define the core action that means real value - exporting a project, working with a teammate - not a login.
Execution Group users into weekly or monthly cohorts by the week they finished onboarding and follow them.
Data collection Plot retention per cohort and watch whether the curve flattens or keeps decaying toward zero.

FALSE POSITIVE

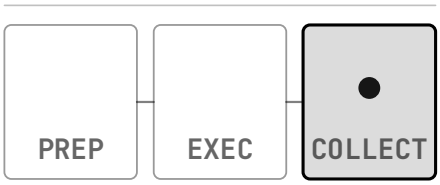
The Walking Dead Metric Trap

Top-line registered users can grow while every cohort decays to zero; growth stalls when spend slows.

The source names no originator.

Sean Ellis PMF Survey Engine (The 40% Rule)

We believe our product has achieved early product-market fit within its core user segment. We will verify this by surveying users who have experienced the core product at least twice in the past fortnight, and consider it validated if ≥ 40% state they would be "very disappointed" if the product disappeared tomorrow.



SCHEMATIC

Read at step 3 of the 3-step strip

I34

Sean Ellis PMF Survey Engine (The 40% Rule)

METHOD

Time: 7–14 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: High (Diagnostic survey)

PLAN

Preparation Ask one question - how would you feel if you could no longer use it - with four fixed answers.
Execution Send it only to users who finished onboarding and used the product more than once.
Data collection Compute the very-disappointed share and segment it to find where satisfaction is strongest.

FALSE POSITIVE

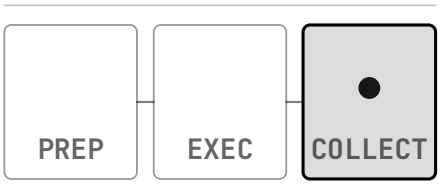
Surveying Casual, Non-Core Users

Surveying casual users who signed up and bounced pulls the score down and hides fit.

Source: Sean Ellis & Morgan Brown (2017). *Hacking Growth: How Today's Fastest-Growing Companies Drive Breakout Success.* Currency.

Net Promoter Score and Root-Cause Decomposition

We believe that users advocate organically for our product. We will verify this by running an in-app Net Promoter survey with open-ended follow-up prompts, and consider it validated if the overall score meets or exceeds +40, with ≥ 50% of Promoters pointing to the same core capability as their primary reason for recommending it.



SCHEMATIC

Read at step 3 of the 3-step strip

I35

Net Promoter Score and Root-Cause Decomposition

METHOD

Time: 7–10 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: Moderate

PLAN

Preparation Add the 0-10 rating prompt after a user completes a core milestone, not at random.
Execution Sort answers into promoters, passives and detractors, then ask each for the reason behind the score.
Data collection Compute NPS = % Promoters − % Detractors.

FALSE POSITIVE

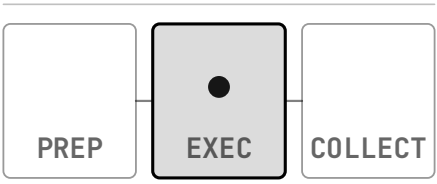
Passive Satisfaction Inflation

High passives (7-8) look healthy but those users switch for price or features.

Source: Frederick F. Reichheld (2003). *The One Number You Need to Grow.* Harvard Business Review.

Feature-Flagged Canary Experiment

We believe that [Redesigned Workflow X] increases task completion rates compared to the current baseline. We will verify this by deploying the redesign to 10% of production traffic via an open-source feature flag, and consider it validated if the treatment group shows a statistically significant lift in task completions (≥ 15%, $p < 0.05$) without degrading error rates or latency.



SCHEMATIC

Split at step 2 of the 3-step strip

I36

Feature-Flagged Canary Experiment

METHOD

Time: 7–14 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: Extreme (Empirical statistical comparison)

PLAN

Preparation Put the new workflow behind a feature flag with exposure keys and logging attributes.
Execution Split 10% of traffic at random, watch errors, then raise to 50% once it is stable.
Data collection Compare conversion, errors, latency and completion time between control and treatment.

FALSE POSITIVE

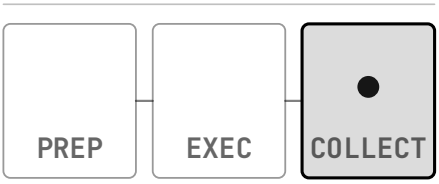
Early Peeking and Underpowered Samples

Stopping when p dips below 0.05 inflates false positives; lock sample size and duration first.

The source names no originator.

Unit Economics Stress Test (CAC:LTV Ratio)

We believe our customer acquisition model is economically sustainable. We will verify this by measuring blended and paid Customer Acquisition Costs alongside early cohort churn and revenue, and consider it validated if the projected Lifetime Value to Customer Acquisition Cost ratio exceeds 3:1, with full CAC payback achieved in ≤ 12 months: LTV / CAC ≥ 3.0, where LTV = (ARPU × Gross Margin) / Churn Rate



SCHEMATIC

Read at step 3 of the 3-step strip

I37

Unit Economics Stress Test (CAC:LTV Ratio)

METHOD

Time: 30–60 days · Cost: $500–$$$$ · Confidence: High

PLAN

Preparation Aggregate fully loaded acquisition costs across a 60-day window: spend, commissions, overhead, tools.
Execution Track paid customer accounts generated specifically from those spend allocations.
Data collection Calculate CAC payback months and the projected LTV to CAC ratio.

FALSE POSITIVE

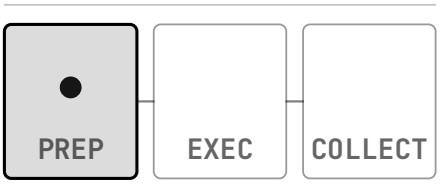
Blended CAC Smuggling

Blending organic traffic with paid spend hides high paid acquisition costs and an unviable channel.

The source names no originator.

Minimum Viable Experiment (MVE) Timeboxing

We believe we can determine whether to pursue [Hypothesis X] in five business days. We will verify this by running a structured, strictly timeboxed five-day testing sprint, and consider it validated if the team gathers enough behavioral data to pass an agreed quantitative validation gate by Day 5.



SCHEMATIC

Timebox at step 1 of the 3-step strip

I38

Minimum Viable Experiment (MVE) Timeboxing

METHOD

Time: 5 business days · Cost: $0–$100 · Confidence: Moderate

PLAN

Preparation On Monday, isolate one critical unknown and design a test that can finish inside one week.
Execution Build Monday and Tuesday, run live Wednesday and Thursday, close collection Friday at midday.
Data collection Present raw results Friday and force the decision: validate, invalidate or kill.

FALSE POSITIVE

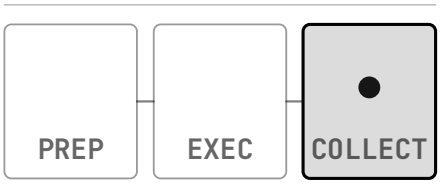
Sunk Cost Rationalization Extensions

Teams extend a deadline when results look bad, hoping another few days salvages the hypothesis.

The source names no originator.

Micro-Conversion Step Drop-Off Audit

We believe that [Step 3 in our onboarding flow] causes unnecessary user drop-off. We will verify this by instrumenting telemetry across every form field and screen transition, and consider it validated if simplifying that single step reduces drop-off by ≥ 30% without lowering downstream activation quality.



SCHEMATIC

Read at step 3 of the 3-step strip

I39

Micro-Conversion Step Drop-Off Audit

METHOD

Time: 7–14 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: High

PLAN

Preparation Map every input field, click and screen transition in the target path into one sequential funnel.
Execution Log drop-off, validation errors and interaction time for every field across 500 sessions.
Data collection Plot the drop-off gradient across each micro-step to find the friction points.

FALSE POSITIVE

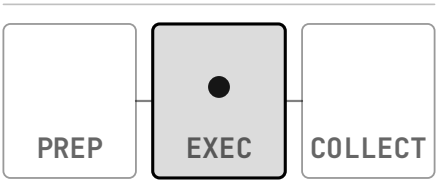
Removing Essential Friction

Cutting identity checks or qualification questions lifts completion and floods you with spam.

The source names no originator.

Paid Pilot Milestone Contract Verification

We believe enterprises will pay for our complete workflow solution. We will verify this by executing 3 paid commercial pilot agreements with explicit performance milestones, and consider it validated if at least 2 enterprise accounts meet their operational criteria and convert to multi-year contracts upon completion.



SCHEMATIC

Pilot at step 2 of the 3-step strip

I40

Paid Pilot Milestone Contract Verification

METHOD

Time: 30–60 days · Cost: $0 · Confidence: Extreme

PLAN

Preparation Draft a pilot agreement with target milestones, integration dates and auto-converting production pricing.
Execution Deploy inside the enterprise and support the team until it hits the agreed milestones.
Data collection Track the contractual metrics and how many pilots convert to multi-year production licences.

FALSE POSITIVE

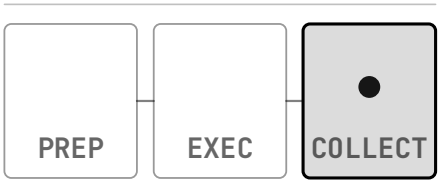
Perpetual Pilot Trap

Buyers use cheap pilots to run exploratory tests or meet an innovation quota, never to roll out.

The source names no originator.

Referral Engine and Viral Coefficient (K-factor) Test

We believe that our product includes natural referral loops that drive organic growth. We will verify this by adding an in-product referral mechanism to active user workflows, and consider it validated if the measured Viral Coefficient (K) exceeds 0.40: $K = i \times c$ where i represents invitations sent per active user, and c represents the conversion rate per invitation.



SCHEMATIC

Read at step 3 of the 3-step strip

I41

Referral Engine and Viral Coefficient (K-factor) Test

METHOD

Time: 14–30 days · Cost: $0–$100 · Confidence: High

PLAN

Preparation Put the referral inside the value loop - invite a collaborator to the document - not on a marketing button.
Execution Track invitations, link shares and signups across 300 active users.
Data collection Compute the loop variables over time and the cycle time from signup to invited user joining.

FALSE POSITIVE

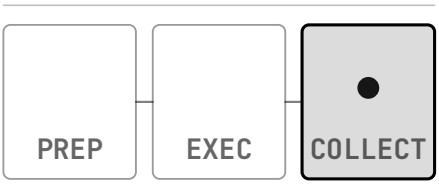
Artificial Incentive Distortion

Cash rewards buy spam invites that inflate the coefficient and bounce after the payout.

The source names no originator.

Formal Pivot vs. Persevere Evaluation

We believe our recent experimentation results provide sufficient empirical evidence to guide our next strategic product cycle. We will verify this by evaluating our cumulative testing metrics against predetermined milestone gates, and consider it validated if the cross-functional leadership team reaches unanimous consensus on an operational path forward (Persevere, Pivot, or Terminate).



SCHEMATIC

Decision at step 3 of the 3-step strip

I42

Formal Pivot vs. Persevere Evaluation

METHOD

Time: 1 day · Cost: $0 · Confidence: High (Governance synthesis)

PLAN

Preparation Consolidate every completed test across the four phases into a memo that names what failed.
Execution Convene the review board and judge against three options: persevere, pivot, or terminate.
Data collection Record the decision, the evidence and the resource reallocation in a permanent record.

FALSE POSITIVE

Sunk Cost Fallacy and Identity Entanglement

Teams persevere with disproven ideas because a failed hypothesis feels like personal failure.

The source names no originator.